

Basics of Rationalist Discourse

Summary of the post by Duncan Sabien

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Rationality Freiburg

0. Expect good discourse to require energy.

1. Don't say straightforwardly **false** things.

2. Track (for yourself) and distinguish (for others) your **inferences** from your **observations**.

3. Estimate (for yourself) and make clear (for others) your rough **level of confidence** in your assertions.

4. Make your claims **clear**, **explicit**, and **falsifiable**, or explicitly acknowledge that you aren't doing so (or can't).

5. Aim for **convergence on truth**, and behave as if your interlocutors are also aiming for convergence on truth.

6. Don't jump to conclusions—maintain **at least two hypotheses** consistent with the available information.

7. Be careful with extrapolation, interpretation, and summary/restatement—distinguish between **what was actually said**, and what it sounds like/what it implies/what you think it looks like in practice/what it's tantamount to. If you believe that a statement A strongly implies B, and you are disagreeing with A because you disagree with B, explicitly note that “A strongly implies B” is a part of your model.

8. Allow people to **restate, clarify, retract, and redraft** their points, if they say that their first attempt failed to convey their intended meaning; do not hold people to the first or worst version of their claim.

9. Don't weaponize equivocation/don't abuse categories/don't engage in **motte-and-bailey** shenanigans.

10. Hold yourself to the **absolute highest standard** when directly modeling or assessing others' internal states, values, and thought processes.

Source

Basics of Rationalist Discourse

Duncan Sabien

<https://www.lesswrong.com/posts/XPv4sYrKnPzeJASuk/basics-of-rationalist-discourse-1>

1. Don't say **false shit** omg this one's so basic what are you even doing. And to be perfectly fucking clear "false shit" includes **exaggeration for dramatic effect**. Exaggeration is just another way for shit to be false.

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2. You do **NOT** (necessarily) know what you fucking saw. What you **saw** and what you **thought about it** are two different things. Keep them the fuck straight.

3. Performative overconfidence can go suck a bag of dicks. **Tell us how sure you are**, and don't pretend to know shit you don't.

4. If you're going to talk **unfalsifiable twaddle** out of your ass, at least fucking **warn us first**.

5. Try to **find the actual factual goddamn truth** together with whatever assholes you're talking to. Be a **Chad scout**, not a **Virgin soldier**.

6. One hypothesis is not e-fucking-nough. You need **at least two**, AT LEAST, or you'll just end up rehearsing the same dumb shit the whole time instead of actually thinking.

7. One great way to fuck shit up fast is to conflate the **antecedent**, the **consequent**, and the **implication**. DO NOT.

8. Don't be all like “nuh-UH, nuh-UH, you SAID!” Just **let people correct themselves**. Fuck.

9. That **motte-and-bailey** bullshit does not fly here.

10. Whatever the fuck else you do, for fucksake do not fucking ignore these guidelines when **talking about the insides of other people's heads**, unless you mainly wanna light some fucking trash fires, in which case GTFO.

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why does lesswrong suddenly feel good and homey

Reply

Source

Fucking Goddamn Basics of Rationalist Discourse

Logan Strohl

<https://www.lesswrong.com/posts/gPPdYTwPkdvAEYyEK/fucking-goddamn-basics-of-rationalist-discourse>

Motte and Bailey



Image source: totalbattleminiatures.com

Motte and Bailey

Bailey (controversial claim):

“We need to abolish the police.”

Motte (defensible retreat):

“We should reform problematic aspects of policing and explore alternative approaches to public safety.”

Equivocation

Since only **man** is rational.
And no woman is a **man**.
Therefore, no woman is rational.

Equivocates “man” between:

- First use: **human being**
- Second use: **male person**

Source: T. Damer, *Attacking Faulty Reasoning* (via Wikipedia)

Abusing Categories

A situation has 3 out of 7 markers of “gaslighting” → someone uses the term.

The problem: Others hear “gaslighting” and assume **all 7 markers** are present (plus their own associations), not just the 3 that were actually observed.

Done intentionally: weaponized equivocation

Done accidentally: still causes confusion and misunderstanding